



BB joins the bandwagon

With the launch of PlayBook apps will soon need to be written for this tablet too. Such opportunities keep opening up for app developers

Learn for free

The good folk over at mobile.tutsplus.com offer free development tutorials for all major mobile platforms, and here's the kicker - it's all free

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the course of the last seven years we felt that there is wide gap between the knowledge imparted by universities and that required for the market place and so we thought of creating modular training programs to augment the university training available to most engineers", said Sushant, CTO of Porting Lab that runs EDUMobile. Devi Ahilya college in Indore offers an M Tech in Mobile Technologies and companies too are trying to bridge the divide between academically qualified candidates and employable ones.

"As Windows Phone 7 launches, we've put in place a lot of support systems for developers. Be it access to devices to test their applications, access to the latest SDKs, and even getting their applications on to the marketplace. DreamSpark (www.dreamspark.com) is such an initiative that gives out free tools such as Visual Studio to students. In India we have about 3 million students who are part of these programmes", said Mr. Moorthy Uppaluri, General Manager, Developer Partner Evangelism, Microsoft India. Though diversity is desirable it's not always favourable in all cases. The MIS type of enterprise developers generally work in platform specific teams. Hence the opposite, leading to specialisation.

Knowledge base

If students want to gain capability, they should have the requisite skill sets to develop across all Platforms. A platform is like a Channel of distribution. If you have expertise on only one type of Platform you are leaving out opportunities to monetize on other channels. If you're comfortable say with development in J2ME and want to port on to the Symbian platform you need to look at developing a few ancillary skills. "Qt is a good place to start" says Anup C Shan who is a web developer at Oracle and builds mobile apps as a hobby. "It's Nokia's latest cross-platform application and UI framework. It's used for the KDE environment on Linux and is platform independent. With Qt you can write code once and it'll (supposedly) work on all Symbian, Maemo and Meego devices. Besides, there's a decent amount of documentation available online. Symbian C/C++ which is like objective C and gives decent performance for games is being phased out by Nokia because it's a little painful to code. Then there is the Pys60 project which has ported python to Symbian. All you need to know is Python - which is not really taught anywhere as such,

but very easy to pick up if you know object oriented concepts. Nokia Web Runtime (WRT) is for web developers to write widgets in HTML/JS/CSS. If you know basic web development, you know how to use WRT. It's very easy to write code in but you don't have as much flexibility/access to platform stuff as the other three options," concludes Anup. Similar is the case for the Windows Phone 7 platform. "We have come up with a completely new architecture, but as long as you know C#, Silverlight or .Net you can develop for the Windows platform" said Mr. Moorthy Uppaluri, General Manager, Developer Partner Evangelism, Microsoft India. Though diversity is desirable it's not always favourable in all cases. The MIS type of enterprise developers generally work in platform specific teams. Hence the opposite, leading to specialisation.

Is code enough?

Mobile app development has two factors to it - coding and user experience. "Even if you've written highly optimised code but



"Being an independent application developer is a lucrative but slightly risky career option. But say you get your app featured on an App store and it becomes very popular, you may not make much money off it, but it will be of immense value when seeking a job"

Sushant Das, CTO, Chakra Interactive (EDU Mobile)

have not paid attention to how a user will interact with the application, it will fall flat," said Moorthy from Microsoft. Developers must have design/interface skills in addition to technical knowledge. In India coding is not the differentiator. According to Noaman, "Multi touch, Pinch to Zoom, Accelerometers, are the trends and App developers have to use these concepts to make the experience richer, enticing and exciting - the underlying technology is a mere tool for which the developer's expertise is a basic hygiene requirement."

Pay Scales and Career Path

Pay scales in App development companies are a little higher than those of IT professionals from other backgrounds such as Java or .Net, simply because of current demand. iPhone and Android developers

Resource Central

- http://www.forum.nokia.com/Library/Tools_and_downloads/
- <https://garage.maemo.org/projects/pys60/>
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- <http://na.blackberry.com/eng/developers/started/>
- <http://developer.bada.com>
- <http://create.msdn.com/en-US/>

are more preferred right now. By and large freshers can expect to make anywhere between 2.5 to 3 lakhs.

"Most of the IT companies in India have Mobile Software departments and the exploding Smart phone market is a big opportunity for everyone. On an average anyone with one year of experience in iPhone or Android gets anywhere from Rs. 25,000 to Rs. 35,000 per month", said Sushant. "Candidates are expected to pick up languages and programming concepts through their formal education course but not so much the actual working on develop-

ment tools."

From a fresher's hiring standpoint we check analytical ability and algorithm making ability at entry point," added Siddharth from RapidSoft. Companies depending on their size can take candidates who have trained with say Aptech or NIIT, or depending on their hiring guidelines insist on Engineering/MCA degrees. When hiring freshers, companies put them through about six months of training, in which they make them conversant with the different platforms and technologies. In RapidSoft the career path goes something like this - Junior Developer, Program Lead, Team Lead, Project / Delivery Manager. The position of Project Manager can be attained in about 10 years and people in this position can hope to conservatively draw 14 to 17 lakhs. The sky is the limit. 